an assurance that Warner Brothers usually took longer than six months to evaluate a new contract player, but he wasn't very successful. That evening, he invited me to his home for dinner and afterward we went to the midget auto races at Gilmore Stadium where I glanced up at the lights of the press box and saw a group of reporters and broadcasters enjoying themselves. It hit me for the first time that I was now only a guy in the grandstand, not a member of the working press, and I wondered how long it would be before I was back in the press box.

Hollywood studios in those days churned out two kinds of pictures—A movies, which led a double bill and featured major stars who could attract customers into a theater, and low-budget B movies, which featured newcomers and lesser-known character actors and filled out the second half of the bill. Like other newcomers, I was assigned to the Warner Brothers B Unit.

Besides filling out their double bills, the studios used B pictures a lot like companies in some industries now use their research and development departments. After they'd put new actors or actresses under contract, they'd cast them in a B picture to test the audience reaction to them. If they seemed to click with the audience, based on the fan mail they received and the response to them at sneak previews, they were given more important parts and then slipped into an A movie in a minor role to further test whether they had the potential to be a star.

Maybe it wasn't intentional, but my first role at Warner Brothers sure seemed like typecasting: I was assigned to play a radio announcer in a movie initially called *Inside Story*, then renamed *Love Is on the Air*. It was a typical B movie—made in a hurry and forgettable.

My preparations for the part consisted of a day with a dialogue coach; at least it was a day longer than the preparation I'd had for my radio announcer's job in